British Expansion Beyond Indian Frontiers (Nepal, Burma and Afghanistan, 1814-42)

Why expand beyond India?

Commercial profit + territorial revenue + imperial security drove expansion. By 1818 the Marathas had been defeated, but British paramountcy did not mean every Indian territory had been directly annexed.

- Trade income faced competition, the cost of wars and pressure from British industrialists; land revenue increasingly financed government, trade purchases and further conquest.
- China sold tea, silk and nankeen cloth mainly for silver. Opium (including Malwa supplies) and Southeast Asian spices such as cloves/nutmeg helped finance Asian trade.
- New markets and timber, minerals, food and military supplies attracted the Company.
- Securing India and routes to China encouraged frontier buffers and outposts. Expansion was funded substantially by **Indian revenues and Indian soldiers**.



Expansion: mutually reinforcing aims

Control was uneven: Nepal was not annexed; the Afghan occupation failed; Burma was annexed in stages. Do not memorise the source's sweeping claim that Britain permanently controlled Nepal, Afghanistan and the Philippines throughout 1757-1857. Manila's British occupation was brief (1762-64), not conquest of the entire Philippines.

Straits Settlements: Penang acquired **1786**, Singapore settlement founded **1819**, Malacca permanently transferred under the **1824** Anglo-Dutch settlement; the three were combined in **1826**. The source's Penang 1791 and Singapore 1824 dates mix separate events. National Archives of Singapore; Penang Port history.

Anglo-Nepal War (1814-16)

Background and causes

- Gorkha expansion unified the Kathmandu valley from **1768**; Nepal pushed west into Himalayan territories and south toward Bengal/Awadh, while conflict with China limited northern expansion.
- **1801:** Wellesley's treaty provided for a British representative at Kathmandu; the representative withdrew in **1803** amid hostility. This did not annex Nepal.

- Competing expansion, disputed borders (especially Butwal/Terai) and British search for a northern buffer produced war.
- **May 1814:** attack on Company-controlled police posts at Butwal; **October 1814:** Lord Hastings launched the campaign. Hill warfare and Nepalese resistance made the conquest difficult, not an effortless British victory.

Campaign and settlement

Recall battles: Butwal, Almora, Malaun and Makwanpur; British success under commanders including **David Ochterlony** forced settlement.

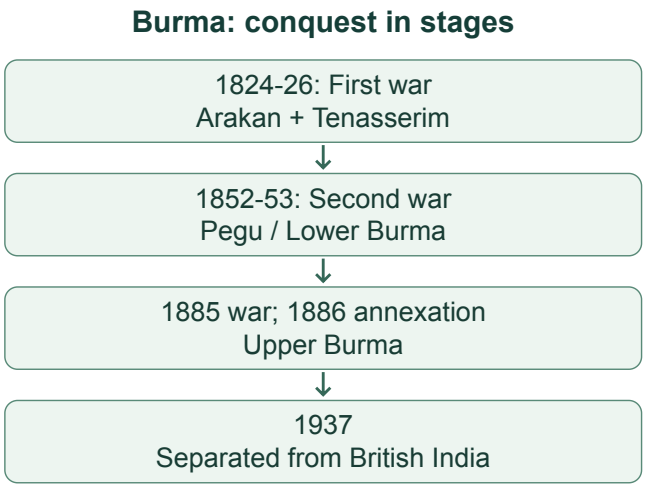
Treaty of Sugauli: agreed **2 December 1815**, ratification exchanged **4 March 1816**. Nepal surrendered claims to extensive western/eastern territories and parts of the Terai; British acquisitions included **Kumaon and Garhwal**, and Nepal accepted a British representative at Kathmandu. Himalayan foothill access became strategically useful. Do not equate the treaty with the founding dates of later hill stations.

Result: Nepal survived as a sovereign buffer; Gurkha recruitment into Company service began during the war, in **1815**. Early recruits included other Himalayan hill groups as well as Gorkhas. The source's claim that Nepal remained neutral in 1857 is misleading: **Jang Bahadur's Nepalese forces helped the British suppress the rebellion**.

Anglo-Nepal war and Gurkha service; Nepal-UK relations.

Burma: three wars, three stages of expansion

War	Governor-General	Cause / pretext	Outcome
First, **1824-26**	Amherst	Burmese expansion into Assam/Manipur and frontier conflict toward Chittagong	Treaty of Yandabo; Arakan and Tenasserim ceded; withdrawal of Burmese claims in northeast
Second, **1852-53**	Dalhousie	Commercial interests and complaints/fines involving British captains at Rangoon	Pegu / Lower Burma annexed; full coast under British control
Third, **1885**	Dufferin	Commercial dispute and fear of Thibaw's French connections	Upper Burma occupied; annexation proclaimed in 1886



Burma: conquest in stages

First war and Treaty of Yandabo

Burmese expansion in **1823-24** brought conflict with British frontier interests. British amphibious attacks included **Rangoon**; Burmese general **Maha Bandula** resisted. Disease, terrain and expense made the war costly.

24 February 1826 - Yandabo: Burma ceded **Arakan and Tenasserim** (including Tavoy/Mergui), renounced claims to **Assam**, accepted the independence of **Manipur**, agreed to diplomatic representation and a substantial indemnity (**£1 million / about ₹1 crore**). Assam/Manipur were not simply territories that Britain had previously possessed and 'regained'.

Map cue: Arakan = western coastal strip; Tenasserim = southeastern coast; Pegu = lower Irrawaddy region; Upper Burma = inland kingdom.

Second and third wars

- A British Resident withdrew in **1839**. Timber for ships, tin, pepper, ivory and rice strengthened commercial ambitions.
- Two captains' complaints/fines furnished Dalhousie's pretext in **1852**. Annexation of Pegu followed in late 1852; 1853 consolidated the outcome. Mindon became king in 1853; **Mandalay was founded as the new capital in 1857**, not immediately in 1853.
- **1885:** Thibaw was removed after the third war. **1886:** Upper Burma formally annexed. Burma became part of British India and was separated as a distinct colony from **1937**.

Afghanistan and the Great Game

Great Game: nineteenth-century Anglo-Russian competition in Central Asia. British fears of a Russian approach to India encouraged intervention in Afghanistan; perceived danger should be distinguished from an imminent invasion actually underway. Earlier anxiety also involved Napoleonic France.

Policy	Core idea
Forward policy	Obtain dominant influence by intervention, a friendly ruler or occupation
Masterly inactivity / stationary school	Watchful non-intervention, diplomatic understanding and frontier defence

These labels developed over time; do not treat all Conservative/Liberal governments as following one unchanging policy. **Palmerston's fears in 1837** helped strengthen the forward argument. Britain's **1832 Reform Act** widened but did not democratise the franchise universally.

First Anglo-Afghan War (1839-42)

Why negotiations failed

Dost Mohammad wanted British help to recover **Peshawar from Ranjit Singh**. Auckland refused to pressure the Sikh ruler, yet expected the Amir to avoid Russia.

- **September 1837:** Alexander Burnes sent to Kabul, nominally for commerce but with political aims.
- **April 1838:** Burnes withdrew after unsuccessful negotiations; the Russian envoy's reception heightened British suspicion.
- **26 June 1838 - Tripartite Treaty:** British, **Shah Shuja** (former Afghan ruler) and **Ranjit Singh**. British expedition commonly called the **Army of the Indus**; not all three signatories contributed identically to the invasion.

Occupation, rebellion and retreat



First Afghan War: policy to failure

Date	Event
1839	Kandahar and Ghazni captured; Shah Shuja installed at Kabul
1840	Dost Mohammad surrendered after renewed resistance; sent to India
1841	Afghan uprising; Burnes and later British envoy Macnaghten killed; Akbar Khan prominent
January 1842	Elphinstone's force retreated from Kabul: about 4,500 troops and 12,000 followers suffered catastrophic losses
April 1842	Shah Shuja killed
1842	Ellenborough replaced Auckland; forces under Pollock/Nott undertook reprisals, rescued prisoners and withdrew

Date	Event
1843	Dost Mohammad restored to power

Shah Shuja lacked legitimacy and depended on a foreign garrison. The retreat had survivors/captives; 'everyone died except one man' is an inaccurate simplification. Reoccupation of Kabul in September 1842 was temporary; destruction of the bazaar and withdrawal did not create durable control.

Evaluation: exaggerated threat assessment, disregard of Afghan independence, weak political intelligence, difficult supply lines and lack of local legitimacy caused an expensive failure. It damaged prestige and contributed to the context of later Sindh/Punjab expansion; those annexations also had their own commercial and political causes. National Army Museum: First Afghan War.

Later Afghan war: a necessary comparison

Second Anglo-Afghan War (1878-80), Lytton: renewed forward policy. **Treaty of Gandamak, 1879**, with **Yakub Khan**: British influence over external relations and a resident at Kabul. The resident was later killed and war resumed; the 1879 treaty did **not** instantly end the entire 1878-80 war. **Abdur Rahman** became Amir in 1880; Britain retained external-policy influence without permanent annexation of Afghanistan.

One-minute recall

Nepal: 1814-16 → Sugauli → buffer + Gurkhas. Burma: 1824-26 / 1852-53 / 1885 → coastal / lower / upper annexation. Afghanistan: 1839-42 → imposed ruler → uprising → retreat → restoration.

No dated PYQs appear in this chapter's supplied pages. Use the wars-and-treaties comparison for recall; the shared subject PYQ files retain earlier questions.